

What else to watch: *Blood Simple* (1984, p.339) ■ *Miller's Crossing* (1990) ■ *The Hudsucker Proxy* (1994) ■ *The Big Lebowski* (1998) ■ *The Man Who Wasn't There* (2001) ■ *True Grit* (2010)



Joel and Ethan Coen Directors

Joel and Ethan Coen have made more than 20 acclaimed

movies. After their first, the sleek thriller *Blood Simple*, they surprised admirers with *Raising Arizona*, a romantic black comedy, and have confounded expectations ever since, fusing darkness with laughs. The Coens often use other movies and

genres as a starting point, before sprawling off in a direction of their own and crafting an off-kilter, funny-scary atmosphere that is entirely their own.

Key movies

1984 *Blood Simple*

1991 *Barton Fink*

1996 *Fargo*

2007 *No Country for Old Men*

police find his victims by the side of the road. The chief of police is Marge Gunderson (Frances McDormand), perhaps the only heavily pregnant detective in the history of cinema.

Uncommon detective

Like everyone else in Brainerd and *Fargo*, Marge has a folksy Scandinavian-American

accent that suggests she's a bit of a bumpkin. But Marge is clearly on the ball. Carefully, she traces the trail of disasters back to Jerry, who's not coping well with the pressure. Macy's study in stress (visible in the close-up far left)

is funny and upsetting, and he turns the folksy regional accent into a rhythm of despair.

Marge (Frances McDormand) inspects the body of a state trooper. Her provincial manner belies a sharp intelligence.

As filmmakers, the Coen brothers are masters of balancing laughs and chills, and thanks to its crime-thriller trappings and wintry landscape, *Fargo* is one of their chilliest works. The tone is set in the opening shot, when the camera peers at a car—Jerry's—threading its way through the blizzard. A doom-laden musical score starts up, and this doesn't feel like a comedy: from the outset there are hints of horror.

Marge is the heart of the story. Her pregnancy is a symbol of hope in the white wasteland of double-crossing and butchery. Although she is never in any real danger, there is a lingering dread that she will be overcome by the movie's violence. But the Coen brothers manage to maintain their masterful balancing act amid the carnage, the nihilism of the case forced to co-star with Marge's deeply rooted decency. ■

“There's more to life than a little money, you know. Don'tcha know that?... I just don't understand it.”

Marge Gunderson / *Fargo*

